

MUSEUM PLANNING LLC

Feasibility Through *Opening Day.*

Forty museums. Twenty-five years. One methodology — and Mark personally involved in every engagement from the first community assessment through post-opening evaluation.

MUSEUMS COMPLETED

40+

AAM PRESS BOOKS

YEARS OF PRACTICE

25

MARK PERSONALLY INVOLVED

2

100%

Mark Walhimer & *Museum Planning LLC*

Museum Planning LLC is a personal practice founded in 1999.

That is a deliberate choice, not a limitation. Every engagement is worked directly — there is no associate who handles the day-to-day while Mark attends the kickoff meeting. When a board asks who they are hiring, the answer is: Mark.

The practice specializes in the full arc of museum development — feasibility through opening day. Community assessment, strategic planning, business planning and pro forma, master planning, exhibition design, capital campaign strategy, operational planning, and post-opening evaluation. More than forty museums over twenty-five years across science centers, art museums, natural history museums, children's museums, history museums, and cultural centers — in the United States, Mexico, and internationally.

Before founding Museum Planning LLC, Mark worked inside institutions at the Children's Museum of Indianapolis, Liberty Science Center, Discovery Science Center, and the Children's Museum of Manhattan. He also served as Chief Operating Officer at a museum fabrication studio. That combination — staff experience, operational knowledge, fabrication reality — is what shapes how he plans.

The plans I produce are designed to be built, not filed. I have been on the other side of the table when a consultant delivers a master plan. I know what happens to that document when the meeting ends.

— MARK WALHIMER, MANAGING PARTNER

40+

MUSEUMS COMPLETED

25

YEARS IN PRACTICE

1992

IN MUSEUMS SINCE

EDUCATION

Pratt Institute — M.S. Industrial Design & Exhibition Design

Skidmore College — B.A. Studio Art

OFFICES

New York · Mexico City · Worldwide

Four Phases. *One Continuum.*

The same process applied across every engagement — from a \$2M university collection to a \$28M regional cultural center. Bad feasibility is still fatal. A museum that can open is not the same as a museum that can stay open.

01

Institutional Planning

Community Assessment · Mission & Vision ·
Feasibility Study · Strategic Planning

Before a single line is drawn, the museum needs a clear strategic foundation — why it exists, who it serves, and whether it can operate sustainably.

Community Assessment

Mission / Vision / Values

Feasibility Study

Strategic Plan

02

Facility Planning

Master Plan · Capital Campaign · Visitor Experience ·
Exhibition Design

Translates institutional goals into physical space and financial reality. Structures the capital campaign required to fund the building and its exhibitions.

Museum Master Plan

Capital Campaign Plan

Visitor Experience Plan

Exhibition Design

Architectural Program

03

Operational Planning

Business Plan · Programming · Marketing ·
Fabrication · Emergency Preparedness

Builds the systems that keep a museum running financially, programmatically, and physically. Personnel accounts for 60% of annual budget — rigorous modeling is not optional.

Business Plan & Pro Forma

Programming Plan

Marketing Plan

Fabrication Oversight

Emergency Response Plan

04

Opening & Operations

Grand Opening · Community Impact · Evaluation ·
Institutional Assessment

A successful opening is planned, not improvised. Post-opening assessment closes the loop and initiates the next strategic planning cycle.

Opening Day Plan

Community Impact Assessment

Exhibition Evaluation

Institutional Assessment

What We Deliver. *What It Costs.*

Typical fee ranges so you know what ballpark you are in before we talk. Every engagement begins with a conversation — one hour, no cost, no obligation. All fees exclusive of travel.

SERVICE	TYPICAL RANGE	WHAT IT PRODUCES
Museum Assessment Starting point · Minimum retainer	\$18,000+ + travel	Current-state evaluation of institutional health, community position, and planning readiness.
Feasibility Study Before capital is committed	\$40k – \$70k + travel	Attendance projections, operating cost modeling, staffing requirements, revenue assumptions.
Strategic Planning Mission, vision, multi-year roadmap	\$45k – \$75k + travel	Mission, vision, and values framework with a multi-year strategic plan.
Museum Master Plan Building program through capital campaign	\$100k+ + travel	Building program, floor plans, phasing, budget, and capital campaign structure.
Exhibition Design Concept through fabrication-ready documentation	\$60k – \$200k + travel	Content, space, sequence, interpretation — from concept through fabrication-ready CAD documentation.
Owner's Rep / PM Construction & fabrication oversight	Variable per scope	Owner's representation through construction and fabrication — on schedule, within budget.

Forty Museums. *One Methodology.*

From university natural history collections to city-led cultural centers — across the United States and worldwide.

#	MUSEUM	LOCATION	TYPE	YEAR
01	Howard Natural History Museum	Riverside County, CA · \$27.75M	Master Planning	2024
02	Frehner Museum of Natural History	Southern Utah University	Master Planning	2026
03	Arizona Natural Resources Museum	University of Arizona · Tucson	Master Planning	2023
04	Museum of Arts and Sciences	Macon, Georgia	Exhibition Design	2025
05	Interactive African American Museum	Indiana	Exhibition Design	2022
06	MIDE, Museo Interactivo de Economía	Mexico City, Mexico	Exhibition Design	2019
07	Museo Memoria y Tolerancia	Mexico City, Mexico	Exhibition Design	2016
08	The Tech Interactive	San Jose, California	Exhibition Design	2019
09	Alcatraz Life on the Rock	United States · Traveling Exhibition	Exhibition Design	2019
10	Children's Museum of Indianapolis	Indianapolis, Indiana	Exhibition Design	2013
11	Discovery Science Center	Orange County, California	Master Planning	2013
12	City of McDonough — African American Museum	McDonough, Georgia	Master Planning	2019
13	Discovery Center at Murfree Spring	Murfreesboro, Tennessee	Exhibition Design	2020
14	Cade Museum — STEAM Music Concept	Gainesville, Florida	Master Planning	2017
15	Children's Museum of Manhattan	New York, New York	Exhibition Design	2012

+ 25 additional projects · museumplanning.com/projects

Measuring What *Actually Matters.*

A proprietary 0–100 composite scoring framework where every metric is normalized for institutional size. A \$500K museum with strong ratios can outrank a \$25M institution.

01	02	03	04	05
Visitor Experience	Digital Presence	Financial Health	Community Impact	Institutional Strength
TripAdvisor & Google ratings weighted for volume. Management response rate.	Instagram followers per \$1M operating budget. Posting consistency.	Revenue per visitor. Surplus % of revenue. Endowment ratio.	Visitors per local capita. Programming breadth. AAM accreditation.	Years operating. Collection depth normalized for size.

LIVE EXAMPLE — CONNECTICUT RIVER MUSEUM • ESSEX, CT • FY2024

MUSEUM VITALITY INDEX • ASSESSMENT REPORT

Connecticut River Museum • Essex, CT • FY2024

MVI SCORE

79/100

B+ • Strong

VISITOR EXPERIENCE

16/20

KEY FINDINGS

DIGITAL PRESENCE

17/20

3.6×

Instagram reach vs. Mystic Seaport per \$1M budget

FINANCIAL HEALTH

15/20

COMMUNITY IMPACT

16/20

5 yrs

Consecutive operating surplus including pandemic

INSTITUTIONAL STRENGTH

15/20

14.9%

Net surplus as % of revenue FY2024

— START A CONVERSATION

Every museum begins with a *conversation.*

One hour. No cost. No obligation. Tell us where you are and what you are trying to build — whether that is a feasibility question, a capital campaign, a historic building looking for a mission, or a collection that has never been seen by the public. Mark is personally involved in every engagement and ready to begin within two weeks of an executed agreement.

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